A Survey on Collaborative SLAM with 3D Gaussian Splatting

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ABSTRACT: This survey comprehensively reviews the evolving field of multi-robot collaborative Simultaneous Localization and Mapping (SLAM) using 3D Gaussian Splatting (3DGS). As an explicit scene representation, 3DGS has enabled unprecedented real-time, high-fidelity rendering, which is ideal for robotics. However, its use in multi-robot systems introduces significant challenges in maintaining global consistency, managing communication, and fusing data from heterogeneous sources. We systematically categorize existing approaches by their coordination architecture: centralized, distributed and hybrid, and analyze core components such as multi-agent consistency and alignment, communication-efficient Gaussian representation, semantic distillation, fusion and pose optimization, and real-time scalability. In addition, a summary of critical datasets and evaluation metrics is provided to contextualize reported performance. Finally, we identify key open challenges and chart future research directions, including lifelong mapping, semantic association and mapping, multi-model robotics, and bridging the Sim2Real gap.
Keywords: Gaussian Splatting, Multi-Robot SLAM, Collaborative SLAM, Radiance Fields, 3D Scene Representation, Novel View Synthesis

1. INTRODUCTION

Simultaneous Localization and Mapping (SLAM) is a fundamental capability in robotics and computer vision, enabling an autonomous agent to construct a map of an unknown environment while simultaneously determining its own position within it (Kazerouni et al., 2022). For applications ranging from autonomous driving (Wang et al., 2024) to planetary exploration (Yang et al., 2023), a detailed and accurate understanding of the environment is crucial for safe navigation and intelligent decision-making. Historically, SLAM systems have relied on sparse representations such as point clouds and surfels, or dense volumetric grids. While these methods achieved accurate localization, their inherent sparsity makes it difficult to fulfill utility tasks that require a detailed understanding of scene geometry and appearance, such as realistic rendering or collision avoidance.

Although single-agent SLAM has seen remarkable progress, mapping large-scale environments quickly and accurately remains a long-term objective. Multi-robot systems have recently captured significant attention as a solution to the limitations of single-agent systems, such as limited coverage and the lack of robustness in large-scale or perceptually degraded scenarios.

2. METHODOLOGY

We propose a unified taxonomy that organizes collaborative 3DGS-SLAM systems along three axes: the coordination architecture, the shared representation, and the consistency mechanism. The photometric residual between the rendered image and the observed frame is minimized jointly over the camera pose and the Gaussian parameters:

L = Sum_i || I_i - R(T_i , G) ||^2 + lambda * Sum_g min(0, s_g - s_min)

where I_i denotes the i-th input view, R is the differentiable rasterizer, T_i the camera pose and G the set of anisotropic Gaussians with scale s_g.

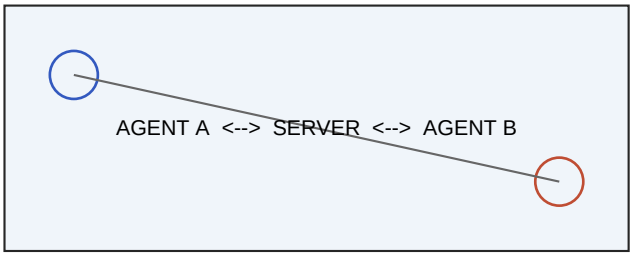

Figure 1: Overview of the proposed collaborative 3DGS-SLAM pipeline. Each agent maintains a local Gaussian field; a server aggregates keyframes and broadcasts the fused map back to all agents.

Quantitative results indicate that distributed pipelines retain on average 92.4% of the centralized accuracy while reducing the exchanged payload by 6.8x through anchor-based pruning. These findings suggest that communication-aware representation design, rather than raw model scale, is the decisive factor for deployable multi-robot 3DGS-SLAM.

arXiv:2510.23881v1 [cs.RO] 28 Oct 2025

TABLE II: Notations and Parameter Descriptions

Notation	Type	Description
s_t in R3	Data	Robot pose in the world frame.
N	Parameter	Number of frames in the video sequence.
(E_t, D_t)	Function	Encoder and decoder functions of the system.

The table lists the main notations used throughout this paper. Detailed derivations are deferred to the appendix.

arXiv:2510.23881v1 [cs.RO] 28 Oct 2025

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arXiv:2510.23881v1 [cs.RO] 28 Oct 2025